

Towards a Tantric Nondualist Ethics through Abhinavagupta's Notion of *Rasa*

In a famous pronouncement on the defects of India's monistic traditions, the German scholar, Paul Hacker declared that *advaita*, or nondualist, traditions could never hope to achieve the ethical preeminence of Christianity since in the ultimate analysis, in a world where all is ultimately the "absolute one", there is no room for the ethical engagement inspired by the Other.¹

Historically, there is much interesting context to this story. Paul Hacker was, after all, a committed convert to Catholicism, and not infrequently does one detect the enthusiasm of his religious commitment in his writings elsewhere. Further than this, however, his compatriot Paul Deussen formulated precisely what Hacker deems impossible, a notion of ethical action based on a nondualist apprehension of the world. Deussen proposes that a universal identification might in fact form the basis of an ethical appreciation of the other. That is, since all beings are essentially my Self, I extend the love I have towards my self to all other beings.² Later the charismatic Vivekananda, after meeting Deussen, also promulgated a path of ethical interaction in his work *Practical Vedanta*, which expresses a quotidian ethical appreciation of the other as founded on the deeper identity of self and other in a nondualist Vedānta.³

However, Vedānta is not the only form of nondualism that India has to offer. Some Tantric traditions as well present nondualist systems offering complex renditions of self and other, where the "absolute one" entails a great deal of nuanced interrelation and reflexivity. I propose here that the writing of the 10th century Tantric Abhinavagupta on aesthetics offers a way into understanding how a nondualist philosophy might address the ethical complexity of human interrelations.

This preliminary examination of the ethical implications of Abhinavagupta's thought focuses on one of his most influential aesthetic works, the *Eye of the Light on Suggestion* (*Dhvanyālokalocana*). In this paper I suggest that for Abhinavagupta, the aesthetic appreciation of a poem or a play entails a non-linear and non-rational encounter with delight in the appreciation of the *rasa*, or "flavor" of the art that lends itself ultimately to moral refinement through a process of universalization. What I find especially interesting and compelling in Abhinavagupta's formulation is precisely that he links the aesthetic experience of an emotional, non-linear and non-rational apprehension of "savoring a flavor" to a process of universalization-- against what we might expect as Westerners schooled on Kant and Kierkegaard where the universal appears implicitly aligned with the rational and linear, rather than with the emotions, the non-rational or non-linear. It is this universalization derived from the subjective appreciation of the emotion in art I suggest that offers unanticipated possibilities for generating an ethical position in Abhinavagupta's nondualist philosophy.

In what follows below I first lay out the parameters of the problem of ethics that Hacker sees in Indian nondualist philosophies. Following this, I will address the concept of aesthetic experience through *rasa*. With this I note the interpersonal ramifications of *rasa*'s non-worldly (*alaukika*) component and of the wonder (*camatkāra*) that it engenders. After this I touch on the "dialogue of the heart," the *hṛdayasaṁvāda* that *rasa* entails. Following this I discuss the relationship *rasa* bears to emotion and then how the process of universalization involved in aesthetic experience is key in creating a ground for ethical participation. I follow this with Abhinavagupta's explicit understanding of the ethical component of aesthetic experience.

THE PROBLEM WITH NONDUALISM

In addressing Hacker's concerns, first, we ought to be aware that Hacker's critique of Indian nondualist systems presupposes a kind of structuralist reductionism of monism. Hacker reasons that the underlying structural model of nondualism ultimately makes any concern for the other irrelevant. However, even if nondualist models ultimately--and the key term here is ultimately--deny the validity of the world with its plethora of others whose existence and desires must be reconciled with our own in an ethical framework, nevertheless Hacker's notion elides a nearly ubiquitous feature of most of these nondual, *advaita*, models: the provisional acceptance of the world for daily behavior. Śaṅkara's *advaita*, for instance, presupposes the level of *vyavahāra*, the ordinary worldly realm, where normative moral rules, such as the prohibition against killing a brahmin, are still operative. Even in the apparent espousal of a totalizing relativism that we find in Nāgārjuna's *Mūlamādhyaṃika Kārika*--a relativism that ultimately denies a proper agent for action in the first place --presumably the founding *sine qua non* of any ethical consideration⁴ --we still find nevertheless, Nāgārjuna's appeal to these two levels, where the world and rules of mundane existence are still in effect. Moreover, it has been amply pointed out that Śaṅkara's nondualist system presupposes a lengthy habituation to normative rules of conduct long before one even begins to consider the goal of enlightenment or liberation, thus, of course, reaffirming this nondualist philosophy's commitment to a socially operative ethical element, which presupposes an aspirant already sufficiently schooled in a lengthy practice of restraint, honesty, neither taking or coveting the property of other folks and celibacy, among other quotidian virtues that we associate with the moral claims of others in a social setting.

On the other hand, even though Hacker's structural reasoning is somewhat specious insofar as it is superficial, one does nevertheless encounter a related problem. Associated with some forms of nondualism, mostly Tantric systems, we find what is sometimes called the "crazy wisdom" practices. Rather than a socially conservative nondualist Vedāntin like Śaṅkara as the culprit bearing the brunt of Hacker's critique, the problems of ethical misconduct are far more frequently associated with these Tantric visions of a world where there is no "other", that is, in Tantric nondualist systems like Abhinavagupta's *advaita* Tantra that we will address here. Textually, we find numerous instances of Tantric

prescriptions to violate ethical norms in the quest to perfect a nondualist vision, such as, for instance, Abhinavagupta's transgressive prescription that the partner for the sex rite even be one's mother.⁵ In this case, for our modern sensibilities the social transgression offends us not simply because it violates a fairly ubiquitous social taboo against incest, but also because it has simply assumed the non-status of that "other" person participating in the rite, the woman. Without the slightest fanfare, the woman's "right to choose" or not to participate has been elided, negating her ethical status as a person.

One could perhaps argue that this oedipal suggestion offers a transgression that is more properly classified as offensive to our sense of social mores than to an inherent violation of a person based ethics. In this case, the cultural gap between the social status of women across the gulf of continents and centuries reflects the differences between these two respective socially constructed ideas of persons. In other words, who counts as a "person" is by no means universally agreed upon. Particularly, this highlights the moral relativism implicit in the very idea of what constitutes a person.

Yet, even if we leave aside the culturally sticky matter of appropriate sexual conduct for nondualist traditions, which are probably the most numerous form of contemporary ethical transgressions--especially since this form of social misconduct seems to cross onto both sides of the dualist-nondualist divide, a problem remains. That is, aside from this, what does one do with the Tibetan Tantric Longchenpa's nondualist dismissal of even murder? Longchenpa teaches a nondualism that rejects any idea of karma and causality as the true understanding of reality. We see him write of a person who understands this truth: "even if one person kills many others with a sharp knife, at that time neither benefit nor harm would accrue to his nature of mind."⁶ Similarly, we find "Since nothing originates in pure mind, to take the life of an ordinary person for example, any presumption of birth and death is misplaced."⁷ A truly nondual vision negates our ordinary ethical relations. Because karma and causality are not operative on this highest level of reality, if we align ourselves with this highest understanding, even dire ethical transgressions such as murder carry no stain.

Here the problem with ethics in this non dualist system appears to be less the lack of an "other" and more the incomprehensibility of the notion of karma--of cause and effect. Further, a nondualist Tantric scheme encourages a translation of this dismissal of normative conventional ethics into ordinary practice.

Indeed, beyond the text, one finds numerous contemporary examples of nondualist ethics nullifying the ethical considerations weighing upon the rest of us. As Jeffrey Kripal points out in a discussion of gurus in America,

the literature is all too full of discussions about the moral failures of any number of prominent guru figures: Bhagwan Rajneesh (whose community was infamous for a depressingly long list of crimes, including drug abuse, sexually transmitted

diseases, phone tapping, food poisoning, fraud, arson, attempted murder, and extradition), Swami Muktananda (who allegedly had sex with a number of women, some quite young, in the years before he died), Chogyam Trungpa, and Osel Tendzin (Trungpa's successor, who knowingly infected one of his male lover-disciples with AIDS), to name a few of the more well known.⁸

Importantly, the prominent figures Kripal cites in his critique of the ethical transgressions of mystics all subscribe to nondualist visions of reality. Further, many of the figures he lists here and elsewhere in his discussion of contemporary gurus who violate contemporary norms are associated with Tantric traditions. The exception here are the Zen teachers in America, who we should emphasize are also philosophically nondualist in their understanding of reality. Does the lack of ethical considerations for those others who were poisoned, sexually abused and so on, derive its justification from these visions of reality as nondual? Is Hacker right that there is something inherent in these Asian versions of nondual reality that predisposes their adherents to a moral desuetude?

As an adumbrated variation on this theme, we might note that elsewhere, even in an apparently dualistic devotional or *bhakti*-driven conception of cosmos, where God and devotee are separate, in the *bhakti* of the *Bhagavad Gītā*-- whenever the distinction between God and the world (as other) begins to dissolve, we begin to encounter the same ethical dilemma. When Kṛṣṇa shows his cosmic form, where he alone encompasses the totality of creation as he alone devours the warring armies, he counsels Arjuna that to kill his cousins is not a sin, since there is no "other" to act as either agent of this karma or as recipient of the slaughter. Kṛṣṇa alone is the totality, performing this murder on beings who were never born and can never die in the first place. The *Gītā* of course shifts back and forth between a dualist and nondualist conception and yet, it is suggestive that it is precisely when the text espouses a nondualist understanding of reality that Arjuna's ethical responsibilities to his kinsmen no longer carry weight.⁹

To briefly summarize this section then and connect it back to an examination of Abhinavagupta's aesthetic theory and the possibilities it presents for ethics: there appears to be some evidence to suggest that nondualist understandings of reality demand at the least a more complicated picture for understanding how one might derive an operative ethics. In particular, Paul Hacker's suggestion that nondualist systems are deficient because they preclude the possibility for ethics may be flawed by a cultural bias, however, his suggestion deserves closer scrutiny and a formulation of precisely how ethical considerations might be derived.

What is particularly compelling and insightfully unanticipated in Abhinava's view is the possibility for generating ethical considerations through the subjective pole of this story, vis à vis the connection of the aesthetic experience with the universal and transcendent. For our 21st century perspective, he combines two unlikely bedfellows; rather than linking the universal to the objective pole of experience, he links the subjective, emotional, non-

linear and non-rational with the universal and transcendent. What does this mean for ethics? I suggest that it affords a way of thinking how a subjective based sense of self, through the subjective experience of emotion, can transcend an impulse toward "selfishness." From this nondualism based on the self, he derives a notion of the universal, that all the while centered on the self as emotionally responsive subject, lifts the subject to a universal level common to all, to a transcendent position.

ABHINAVA'S AESTHETIC EXPERIENCE

What then exactly then does Abhinava's aesthetic experience entail? Abhinava begins with Ānandavardhana's opening definition, "suggestion is the soul of poetry".¹⁰ The power of suggestion, that allusive and elusive element of art is what affords power to a work of art. In this process, the emotion that the work conveys is transformed into something beyond emotion, into aesthetic experience as *rasa*, the "juice" or "savor" that makes art into something beyond ordinary life.

Our experience of this aesthetic transformation is, in a word, delight, "*ānanda*." Perhaps the English word "delight" is too feeble to capture Abhinavagupta's sense of the word *ānanda*. For this aesthetic experience for Abhinavagupta is akin to the experience of the absolute bliss. Abhinavagupta tells us,

"When the *rasa*, or flavor comes into one's purview, then it is enjoyed. This enjoyment is differentiated from what is encountered through memory or direct experience. It is characterized by melting, expansion and opening [of the heart]. It consists of resting, where one melts into tranquility of one's true nature, which is one's own consciousness (*cit*) made up of purity (*sattva*), which has mixed in with it agitation and dull stupidity. It is similar to the taste of the state of the highest absolute (*parabrahma*)."¹¹

The aesthetic experience then,¹² is an enjoyment unlike ordinary experience, unlike memory or *anubhāva*, experience in general. It involves a melting and an opening of the heart and it is comparable to the state of the highest bliss, the supreme Brahman. Here the Sanskrit word for this bliss or delight is *ānanda*, a term that historically references both the state of the absolute in the Vedāntic notion of the supreme as *sac-cid-ānanda*, as being, consciousness and bliss or delight, and at the same time harkens to the *ānanda* of bodily bliss in the Upaniṣads¹³ and later Tantric texts.

For Abhinavagupta, this *ānanda* is literally ensconced in a bodily metaphor. Delight is "chewing the flavor" as he tells us."¹⁴ And elsewhere, "*rasa* is that form that is relished through the function of chewing the delight which is one's own inherent pure awareness."¹⁵ At the same time, this bodily metaphor references something that is beyond the world, it is "*alaukikaḥ*." Abhinavagupta tells us: "That [*rasa*] however cannot be expressed through ordinary language, even in a dream. It does not fall in the sphere of the worldly"¹⁶ Thus, even though it is figured as corporeally down to earth as it gets, with the metaphor of chewing, nevertheless it transcends the ordinary world. This divine bliss might be

imagined as a kind of transcendent Babette's Feast. The process of chewing performs a kind of alchemical transformation through our appreciation of art. As the emotion we see in the performance is transformed by this "chewing", the personal and particular transform into a transcendent awareness.

This alchemical transformation echoes Abhinava's Tantric understanding in his philosophical work, in the *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī*, of the process of refining and transforming the gross into the subtle through interiorization. By interiorizing the object, one recognizes its true nature as the consciousness of subjectivity. What happens here is that "chewing" is internalizing. It would not be idle also to note here that *carvaṇam*, "chewing" is the phase of internalization in Abhinavagupta's disciple Kṣemarāja's four part scheme following the cycle of twelve Kālī-s, whereby one transforms outer experience into inner enlightenment.¹⁷ That is, in religious ritual practice as well, "chewing" is an internalization of the object, transforming it into subjective awareness. In Abhinava's scheme, moving towards the subjective pole of experience is equivalent to the impetus of Sadāśiva in his cosmological understanding--where consciousness withdraws from the external, becomes more subtle, and effectively rises to a position of greater knowledge and greater power. The state of the object and objective world is a kind of alienation from our true expansive self as all encompassing being. Rather than the objective, the world out there, leading to a universalization and all-encompassing perspective, it is the subjective which leads to this.¹⁸

From an ordinary and bodily perspective, when we chew something, we do indeed take something which is solid, dense and transform it literally into a less dense substance, juice. We take that which is foreign, object and assimilate it to our own sense of self, even bodily self in the case of food. This indeed, is one of the things that is most appealing about Abhinavagupta as a philosopher; his profound philosophical and cosmological pronouncements frequently work as well on a mundane and bodily register.

Further, the transcendence that occurs in our appreciation of art operates in a way that one suspects has especially to do with mapping out a way of being in the world that sidesteps what we frequently call "worldly" with its imbricate ramifications of material exchange. This non-worldly "*alaukikaḥ*" element certainly references the other-worldly in the sense that it approximates the non-worldly experience of the bliss of the absolute Brahman. However, as we just noted above, for Abhinavagupta we can expect to find a resonance of this idea of the non-worldly on a mundane level as well. Indeed, for Abhinavagupta, as we find elsewhere in his writings, the highest states of consciousness and bliss recapitulate all through the cosmos, from the highest levels to the lowest. Thus, when he talks about the five powers of creation, destruction, etc. of the highest Lord in his philosophical work, the *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī*, he takes pains to make sure that his readers understand that these five powers exist also even in the lowliest insect.¹⁹ The divine operates all the way through the hierarchy, "*otapṛota*", "from top to bottom"²⁰ from the highest to the lowest. For our purposes here, similarly the non-worldly, *alaukikaḥ*, in

conjunction with its resemblance to the highest bliss, works its way all the way down, finds its resonances in the sphere of human interactions. In this case, the non-worldly engagement references also a way the self interacts with others, a way that may be read to implicate an ethical element within the aesthetic experience.

To unpack this idea at more depth, it may be helpful to look closely at Abhinavagupta's definition of *rasa* and his explanation of the process by which *rasa* occurs. Abhinavagupta tells us, that "all poetry lives through the power of *rasa*" and that "*rasa* is essentially a single undifferentiated dense mass of wonder."²¹ The word "wonder" here in the Sanskrit is "*camatkāra*," a key word in Abhinavagupta's nondual theological system, as is "*ekaghana*", this "single undifferentiated dense mass". "*Camatkāra*" signifies a kind of stopping of time, moving into a nondualist apprehension of self and the self's own inherent divinity outside of a normative sense of socially constructed self. One sees it referenced throughout nondualist Śaiva schools in Kashmir.²² This wonder is rapturous and at the same time, its very rapture suspends the egoic sense of self which pits itself against others. The state of *camatkāra* halts our ordinary worldly egoic relations. That is, we move from a worldly, "*laukika*" engagement with others to a non-worldly, "*alaukika*" engagement.

Rasa arises through a metaphorically gustatory operation. When we taste the mind's mental and emotional leaps and bounds --what I translate as *cittavṛtti* here--these leaps and bounds that arise through encountering an appropriate object, this process generates *rasa*. Thus when we as audience see the heroine rejected by the hero because he does not recognize his lover from their time together earlier in the forest, our minds react emotionally and mentally as we empathize with and judge the characters in the play. It becomes an experience of art when we make a further step and "taste" these emotional and mental reactions. To quote Abhinavagupta: "In that state of mind when one tastes the mental and emotional fluctuations of the mind by means of an appropriate object--that is *rasa*. It is called *bhāva* when the state of mind arises from a transitory emotion."²³ It is this "tasting" the emotion, which internalizes that which is external. Again, like the chewing we saw earlier, the gustatory is never far away in aesthetic appreciation. These states of mind are triggered by what are called *vibhāvas*, the circumstances of a play or poem which cause emotion, such as the characters and their conditions, the forlorn heroine abandoned by her erstwhile lover, for instance, and by *anubhāvas*, the external signs of emotion depicted by a poem or the characters in a play, such as swooning or a tremulousness in the eyes²⁴ and so on. The *rasa* then arises in the audience when a sensitive listener empathetically shifts into a single-minded resonance with the art, the characters, the mood, and the emotions, a resonance that occurs through "dialogue of the heart" that moves the sensitive listener to savor the taste of the *rasa*. In this state, as Abhinavagupta tells us,

"the sensitive critic empathetically unites in an act of relishing the art, tasting it by means of the states of mind, which occurs from the strength of the dialogue of the heart through apprehending the circumstances of the play or poem and the external signs of emotion."²⁵

Thus through a connection, a dialogue of the heart, which comes about through opening one's heart, the empathy of the listener transports the listener to the otherworldly apprehension of *rasa*. The emphasis on the heart is important I think. For this Indian culture and our own also today, the idea of a heart connection implies an absence of egoic calculation of one's own interests. In this context this "opening" allows for a loosening, the melting (*druti*) we saw earlier, of one's entrenched sense of self as separate from others.

From this, however, we should not understand that the sensitive viewer or listener actually experiences the emotion that the other person, the poem or the play depicts.

Abhinavagupta is emphatic on this point. The experience of *rasa* entails a different type of experience altogether. It involves a psychic refinement of these essentially raw elements of the *vibhāvas* and *anubhāvas*. In this process, the emotion is transformed. Thus we see that Abhinavagupta says to his Mīmāṃsaka opponent,

"Do you consider the attainment of *rasa* to be just only the apprehension of the mere mental fluctuations of another? This error should not be made. What kind of state of *rasa*, of relishing, would there be in this mere inference of the mental fluctuations that happen in the world continually? The taste of *rasa* has as its soul an otherworldly wonder."²⁶

Rasa is something quite apart and beyond a simple sympathy. The dialogue of the heart is truly a dialogue and not simply an easy mirroring of the emotion of the other. It involves the process of relishing, a "chewing" of that emotion to refine it to something wondrous. Again Abhinavagupta uses here the word "*camatkāra*," a "wonder," with its implications of a suspended rapturous state outside the ordinary social intercourse of exchange.

Moreover, this savoring of *rasa* is actually not emotion at all, and neither is it merely a sympathetic internalization of the emotions depicted in a play or poem. The fifth verse in the first chapter of the *Dhvanyāloka* tells us that the first poet, Valmiki, created a poem out of the grief he saw in a bird who lost its mate. Abhinavagupta makes it clear for the *Locana's* reader that the poet Valmiki did not experience grief, telling us,

"it should not be supposed that the sage felt grief. In that case, with that suffering, he also would be suffering and having made this, there would not be any room for the soul of this process of aesthetic savoring, of *rasa*. This suffering from pain, however, was not the poet's condition."²⁷

That is, simple internalization of another's emotion, another's grief is not what engenders the transformative wonder of the aesthetic experience. Indeed, as Abhinavagupta tells us elsewhere, we would not return to the theater or revisit a poem if what it evoked in us was the emotion, the grief of the characters.²⁸

Rather by empathetic identification with the bird's grief, Valmiki transformed this grief into the *rasa* of compassion (*karuṇa*). By Valmiki's "chewing" (*carvaṇyā*) on the gestures of wailing and so on that the bird makes, he transforms the emotion from ordinary, everyday

worldly (*laukika*) grief into something that transcends this grief. *Rasa* arises out of the essence of tasting this within one's own mental and emotional ride through the process of internalizing and identifying with the grief. When the emotion is grief, the form the *rasa* takes is compassion.²⁹

Superficially here, we can see in Abhinavagupta's aesthetic theorizing how an ethics might arise out of aesthetic appreciation. The compulsion of compassion presents itself as a basis for an ethical relation to the other. However, compassion is not the only *rasa* in art; it is only one of nine, and other *rasas*, for instance the fierce *rasa*, *raudra*, may not so readily lend themselves to what we might construe as an ethical response to the other, via compassion.

I suggest rather that it is not the emotional quality of the *rasa* itself which proffers an ethical stance, but instead the process of rumination, the "chewing," "*carvaṇa*," involved in transforming emotion into *rasa*, which then in Abhinavagupta's scheme entails a heightened self-awareness of the subject. Thus the ethical moment that one finds in Abhinava's nondual understanding of the process of appreciating art does not hinge on the expectation that all art should engender compassion, but rather that a shift in the self-identity of the viewer or listener causes a transformation that in its basis shatters our normal everyday calculative responses towards others.

In this case it is not the denominative quality of the *rasa*, the emotion it entails, i.e., compassion or fierceness that then engenders an ethical response, but rather the heightened self-awareness that comes from "chewing". That is, the key pivotal operation in this process is a shift that comes about by rumination, by "chewing" these ordinary emotions to the point that this digestion transforms them into something altogether different. Like Shakespeare's eyes that become pearls, and bones that become coral, the ordinary everyday emotion is changed into something rich and strange. There is however still a component of a particular quality attached to the *rasa*. Grief becomes compassion, not simply a quality-free bliss. However, the transformation is not simply from one emotion to another. Something is added in the process which leaves mere emotion behind--a transcendence that passes into a mode of awareness that entails a universalization that bursts the bounds of ordinary egoic identity.³⁰ One tastes and savors a play's emotional life, the circumstances of the play (*vibhāvas*) and the external signs of emotion (*anubhāvas*) to the point that one transforms them into something universal. Abhinava tells us, "And what we call the efficacy of poetry is its bringing the emotional circumstances and so on, to the level of the universal."³¹ A *sādhāraṇatva*-- a making universal of what was a private or personal emotional reaction to an event occurs in the aesthetic response. "*Sādhāraṇatva*," "making universal" connotes as well the application of a rule, a generally applicable principle, suggestive of Kant's notion of the universal as a rule as well. This may be another way of thinking about what Kant's categorical imperative presents, with its rumination on the self as a transcendent self, yet Abhinava derives his position from an expansion of

subjectivity--not erasing the subject through a process of universalization, but rather extending and expanding the subject through the medium of the emotions savored in art.

The notion of *rasa* as a universalization of a particular type of experience, which transcends the dichotomy between the subject and the object and transcends the difference between the actor and the audience is one we see in both Abhinavagupta and his earlier rival and literary opponent Bhaṭṭanāyaka. Lawrence McCrea has suggested that this notion derives from earlier understandings of the function of language derived from classical Vedic exegesis, *mīmāṃsā*, a branch of study devoted to deciphering and explaining India's sacred texts, the Vedas, which ultimately influenced not only philosophical discourse, but also literary theory as well.³² *Rasa's* capacity to transcend the subject and object divide is what affords it its universality and as McCrea points out, "Bhaṭṭanāyaka likens [*rasa*] to the consciousness of the supreme *brahman*."³³ One point of difference between Abhinavagupta and Bhaṭṭanāyaka surfaces here, however. For Bhaṭṭanāyaka, the experience of *rasa* is solely geared towards aesthetic enjoyment, whereas as McCrea notes, for Abhinavagupta "poetry does impart moral and practical instruction."³⁴ I suggest here also that Abhinavagupta's essential equation of the absolute supreme consciousness, the Śiva principle, as the state of subjectivity, the "I" (*ahantā*), moves Abhinava's conception, in any case, towards an ultimately subjective apprehension of the transcendent. That is, the experience of *rasa* impels the sensitive reader of poetry towards a universality that arises out of the sense of subjective experience, a primordial "I" apprehending and chewing the flavor of the poetry.

This universalization is not simply making an emotion universally known, which would be *prasiddha* rather than *sādhāraṇatva*, but rather transforming it in such a way that the encounter involves a transcendence that leaves behind one's everyday egoic self. It is a universality that is common to more than just one's subjective self; but more than this it is a universality that is at base transcendent and universal precisely because it leaves behind the personal as objective identity. That is, implicit in Abhinava's scheme, understanding one's self in an objective way, indeed as object, is bound to leave us cold and calculating. When we become absorbed in the work of art, the poem or play, we heighten the sense and boundaries of the subject; we forget the pettiness and egoity dogging our daily lives. This universality is a type of internally compelling transcendence, which is not emotion per se, but a powerful stepping away from a mundane egoic self, which is always a kind of misreading of self as object. Thus the notion of *rasa* entails something beyond the mere operation of emotion; it points toward a deeply transformative element in the aesthetic encounter that inculcates a sentiment beyond emotion.

Indeed we find that each of the *rasas* when they have transformed the primary emotion into the non-worldly *rasa*, can lead to an ethical commitment because through the transcendent rapture of *camatkāra* that the *rasa* affords, the petty egoic self has been transcended. As Sunthar Visuvalingam points out, love when it becomes universalized "liberates rather than enslaves us to the object of attachment".³⁵ Moreover, for

Abhinavagupta, all of the *rasas*, including the *rasa* of ferocity, *raudra*, have the capacity to afford liberation, precisely because they transform emotion to universalize it beyond the limited sense of self (*pramatr*).³⁶ Liberation in Abhinava's view also does not entail an indifference to the plight of our fellows. Citing a maxim he tells us, "he who has accomplished in himself all that is to be accomplished, will make an effort to achieve the aims of others."³⁷ Even the renouncer, who has realized the self, and chooses to give up desire and the body, ought to give it up not randomly but in an act that benefits another.³⁸ He follows this with a discussion where he connects knowledge of the truth of the self with an attitude of disinterested action for the sake of another:

Whatever is done--teaching, giving of gifts, and finally the abandoning of the body--without reference to one's own interest and for the sake of another, is wholly inconceivable on the part of those who have not acquired a knowledge of the truth of the self.³⁹

In the final estimate, however, I would suggest that it is precisely the emphasis on delight that affords aesthetic appreciation a particularly potent ethical force. The aesthetic experience of delight that arises from tasting the *rasa* opens the heart to a powerful awareness of self and other. As Abhinavagupta tells us in his explanation of the ethical impetus of poetry:

"'just as Rāma is, so I also shall be', thus even as the simile instructs, in the end, we find a surplus beyond this instruction that takes the form of a yawning open of one's own innate imagination through the method of tasting the *rasa*, the flavor."⁴⁰

That element, which goes beyond the instruction to behave as the paradigm of good moral conduct, Rāma, is the *rasa*, a delight that moves the individual out of a bounded sense of self-interest into a universalized, expanded sense of self. The context of this quote is Abhinavagupta's arguments that even though we, as ordinary spectators, cannot really equate ourselves with this incarnation of Viṣṇu who is Rāma, nevertheless, we sympathize with him and his deeds, and through this shift that we make, drawing on an endless store of *saṁskāras*, experiences from many lifetimes, the *rasa* indeed operates in a real way that effects the spectator's shift.

Abhinava makes this argument against the assumption that as ordinary humans we are incapable of understanding the emotional repertoire of divine incarnations. We all harbour within ourselves a vast store of experiences from countless lives. The sensitive reader of poetry is able to draw upon this experience to both sympathize and savor the emotional experiences even of gods, even though such a reader may have never been in any of his or her lives a god like Rāma.⁴¹

This can only happen in a space of delight and wonder where our mundane egoic selves are suspended. And this space I would proffer is ground and basis for a genuine ethical

encounter with an other. Thus we might venture that for Abhinavagupta's nondualism, the ethical transgressions we see associated with nondual teachers, the Rajneeshes and Trungpas that Kripal cites, arise from the lack of aesthetic wonder, a lack of *camatkāra*, in their dealings with others. These ethical failings arise not from nondualism per se, but rather from an inability to really expand the self through the universalization of emotion that savoring the *rasa* brings.

N.B. All translations in this paper are my own unless otherwise specified.

¹ Wilhelm Halbfass, Ed., *Philology and Confrontation: Paul Hacker on Traditional and Modern Vedanta*, (Albany: State University of New York, 1995), 277.

² Halbfass, 1995: 275, 278-280, 283.

³ Swami Vivekananda, "Practical Vedanta" Lectures in London, November 10-18, 1896; in *Complete Works of Swami Vivekananda*, 8 vols.; Calcutta: Advaita Ashram, 1972, vol. 2.,

⁴ Give ref for Mūlamādhyaṃika, The second chapter on motion is a nice example of how Nāgārjuna undercuts the idea of an agent.

⁵ In Tantrāloka 29.101.c-2 and commentary, cited in Sanderson, "Meaning in Tantric Ritual" in *Essais sur le Rituel*, ed., Anne-Marie Blondeau and Kristofer Schipper, (Louvain-Paris: Peeters, Bibliotheque de l'ecole des Hautes Etudes, vol. CII, 1995), 83. The Sanskrit from the TĀ: svapatnī bhaginī mātā duhitā vā subhā sakhī |"

⁶ Longchenpa Rabjampa, *Old Man Basking in the Sun: Longchen Rabjampa's Treasury of Natural Perfection*, Translation and Commentary by Keith Dowman, (Kathmandu: Vajra Books, 2006), 62.

⁷ Longchenpa, trans. by Dowman, *Old Man*, 228.

⁸ Jeffrey Kripal, "Debating the Mystical as the Ethical: An Indological Map" in Jeffrey Kripal and G. William Barnard, ed., *Crossing Boundaries: Essays on the Ethical Status of Mysticism*, (New York: Seven Bridges Press 2002), 53.

⁹ *The Bhagavad-Gītā*, transl., Barbara Stoler Miller (New York: Bantam 2004), 11:33 p.103. It would take us too far afield to explore this here, however, unraveling the links between philosophy and ideology suggestively leads us to the hint that totalizing visions may oddly be what nondualist cosmologies share in common with fascist states, and here I'm thinking especially of Giorgio Agamben's notion of the state of exception as predicated upon an other who is precisely person non grata--the "bare life" that Agamben discusses in Giorgio Agamben, *Homo Sacer: Sovereign Power and Bare Life*, translated by Daniel Heller-Roazen (Stanford, California: Stanford University Press, 1998) However, this merits far more attention than is possible in this paper.

¹⁰ Ānandavardhanācārya, *Dhvanyāloka* with the *Locana* (*Abhinavaguptaviracitayā vyākhyayālankṛtaḥ*) of Abhinavagupta; edited by Durgāprasād and Kaśīnāth Pāṇḍuraṅg Parab, (New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1998; reprint from Bombay: Nirnaya Sagar Press, 1935), 1.1a. p.3: "kāvyasyātmā dhvanirīti".

¹¹ Abhinavagupta, *DhvanyālokaLocana* 2.4; p. 83: "bhāvite ca rase tasya bhogaḥ | yo >nubhavasmarāṇapratipattibhyo vilakṣaṇa eva drutivistaravikāsanāmā rajastamovaicitryānanuviddhasattvamayanijacitsvabhāvanivṛttidrutiviṣṛāntilakṣaṇa parabrahmāsvādasacivaḥ"

¹² The category of the aesthetic that Abhinava gives us is framed specifically as 'poetry.' Thus, the *DhvanyālokaLocana* tells us at the outset that "suggestion is the soul of poetry" ("*kāvyaśyātmā dhvanirīti*"). However, Abhinavagupta understands this category in much broader terms, to signify the aesthetic encounter, referring not only for Abhinavagupta to written or oral poetry, but also to the play as dramatic performance and dance among others.

¹³ For example, *Brhadaranyaka Upaniṣad*, 2.1.19, 2.4.11; also, associated with left handed bodily practices in the *Brhannīla Tantra*, ed., Madhusudana Kaul (Delhi: Butala and Co. 1984), 8.178.

¹⁴ *Locana* 1.1; p. 16 KM ed: "*Ānanda iti || "rasasya carvaṇātmanah.*"

¹⁵ *Locana* 1.3, p. 18 Nirṇaya ed.: *svasaṁvidānandacarvaṇavyāpāraraṣanīyarūpo rasaḥ*

¹⁶ *Locana* 1.3, p. 18, Nirṇaya ed. "Yastu svapne >pi n svaśabdavācyo na laukikavayavahārapatitaḥ."

¹⁷ Sanderson, "Meaning in Tantric Ritual", p. 58.

¹⁸ Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* (IPVV), 3 vols. Edited by Paṇḍit Madhusudan Kaul Shāstrī, (Delhi: Akay Reprints, 1985), 3:254-5, for example and passim.

¹⁹ IPVV 3:260.

²⁰ IPVV 3:255.

²¹ *Locana* 2.3 p.79. "rasenaiva sarvaṁ jīvati kāvyam" and "tasya rasyaikaḥśāntacamatkāratmano." Note that Masson, et. al. translate the word "*camatkāra*" as "aesthetic delight," which misses the very profound theological and religious impetus of the word in Abhinava's philosophical system.

²² A nice example may be found in the *Vijñāna Bhairava*, in Jaideva Singh, *Vijñānabhairava or Divine Consciousness: A Treasury of 112 Types of Yoga: Sanskrit Text with English Translation, Expository Notes, Introduction and Glossary of Technical Terms*, (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1979 [reprint 2003]) which proffers a selection of various techniques, a hundred and twelve, for inducing this divine wonder.

²³ *Locana* Nir. ed. 1.4, p. 28: "aucittiyena pravṛtttau cittavṛtterāśvādyatve sthāyinyā raso vyabhicāriṇyā bhāvaḥ"

²⁴ *Locana* Nir. ed. 1.4, p.29-30.

²⁵ *Locana* 1.4, p. 28 Nir. ed.: "Api tu sahrdayasya hrdayasaṁvādabalādvibhāvānubhāvapratiṭtau tanmayī bhāvenāśvādyamāna eva rasyamānataikaaprāṇaḥ" The rest of this sentence concludes: "siddhasvabhāvasukhādivilakṣaṇaḥ parisphurati." Masson et. al. relates this completed personal happiness to the earlier "joy at having a son," that we find just above this text in the commentary. I suspect that the reason why Abhinavagupta distinguishes between this type of joy and the delight of *rasa* is because the joy of a son is inextricably linked with egoic motives, which makes it untenable and unlike the divine-like delight that arises from the appreciation of *rasa*.

²⁶ *Locana* 1.21, p. 68, Nir. ed.: *kim atra paracittavṛttimātre pratipattireva rasapratipattirabhimatā bhavataḥ | naivaṁ bhramitavyam | evam hi lokagatacittavṛtṭyanumānamātramiti kā rasatā | yastvalaukikacamatkāratmā rasāśvādaḥ*

²⁷ *Locana* 1.5 p. 31-32, Nir. ed.: "Na tu muneḥ śoka iti mantavyam | evaṁ hi sati tadduḥkhena so >pi duḥkhita iti kṛtvā rasasyātmateṭi niravakāśaṁ bhavet | na tu duḥkhasaṁtaptasyaiśā daśeti"

²⁸ Locana 2.4 p. 83, Nir. ed.

²⁹ Locana 1.5, p. 31, Nir. ed. : "Sa eva
tathābhūtavibhāvatadutthākrandādyanubhāvacarvaṇyā
hṛdayasaṁvādatanmayībhavanakramādāsvādyamānatām pratipannaḥ karuṇarasarūpatām
laukikaśokavyatiriktām svacittavṛttisamāsvādyasārām pratipanno rasaḥ
paripūrṇakumbhocchalanavaccittavṛttiniḥspandasvabhāvavāgvilāpādisamayānapekṣi
tve pi"

³⁰ Sunthar Visuvalingam proposes something similar to my idea on this in his
article in "Towards an Integral Appreciation of Abhinava's aesthetics of
Rasa", p.10, presented at the Indic Colloquium, Menla, NY July 2002 found at
<http://www.svabhinava.org/abhinava>; I came across his article after having
formulated my own views on this issue.

³¹ Locana 2.4, p. 83, Nir. ed.: "Taccaitadbhāvakatvaṁ nāma yatkāvyasya
tadvibhāvādīnām sādharmaṇatvāpādanaṁ nāma |"

³² Lawrence McCrea, *Teleology of Poetics in Medieval Kashmir* (Cambridge, MA:
Department of Sanskrit and Indian Studies, Harvard University 2008), pp.55-
98.

³³ McCrea, *Teleology*, p.388.

³⁴ McCrea, *Teleology*, p. 390.

³⁵ Visuvalingam, "Abhinavagupta's Integral Aesthetics" p. 36.

³⁶ Here, the term for the limited sense of self is *pramāṭr*. See also Gerow,
"Abhinavagupta's Aesthetics" translation p.198. Also see Visuvalingam,
"Abhinavagupta's Integral Aesthetics" p. 35.

³⁷ Gerow, "Abhinavagupta's Aesthetics" translation p.202.

³⁸ Gerow, "Abhinavagupta's Aesthetics" translation p.203.

³⁹ Gerow, "Abhinavagupta's Aesthetics" translation p.203

⁴⁰ Locana 2.4, p. 85, Nir. ed.: "yathā rāmastathāhamityupamānātiriktām
rasāsvāadopāya svapratibhā vijṛmbhaṇārūpām vyutpattimante karotīti | I
translate this differently than Masson and Patwardhan, though the sense is
not so different from theirs.

⁴¹ Locana 2.4, p. 85, Nir. ed. McCrea also discusses this passage in the
context of another of the disagreements that Abhinavagupta has with
Bhaṭṭanāyaka.